My first 100 for South Africa

I got my first 100 against New Zealand, during the second Test in Christchurch, in 1999. And I owe it to Gary Kirsten. It happened in the first innings, and I remember being exceptionally focused that day. I didn't play too many loose shots, left balls very well and just played within my strengths.

By then I'd been playing Test cricket for nearly three years and this was my 24th Test. My highest score up till then had been a 54 against the Aussies in Sydney the year before. That day, for some reason, Gary's advice just clicked with me. I mean, we weren't really talking much at the wicket – we never really did – but Gary just kept me focused, telling me what he thought the bowler was trying to do and what the wicket was doing. We kept it simple. From that perspective, I really enjoyed Gary. He was a great thinker.

I not only got a 100 … I turned it into a double: 211 not out. I guess I've never been one to do things in half-measures, have I? I always did like ordering doubles. Actually, I probably could have made more that day, but rain interrupted play and we declared. Jacques Kallis and I set up a 300-run partnership that day – he got 148 not out, if I remember correctly.

Unfortunately, though, almost 90 overs of that Test were lost to rain. The Black Caps had batted first and we'd skittled them for 168 – we then declared on 442/1 and had them at 127/1 before the match was declared a draw.

My first Test 100 at Newlands

My first Test century at my home ground will always be special to me. Not just because I finally scored a 100 there – in the second Test against Pakistan in 2003, so it came pretty late in my Test career – but I turned it into a double again, scoring 228. It was my highest Test score and, after Kiwi Stephen Fleming's 262 against the Proteas in 2006, the second-highest Test score ever at Newlands.

I don't really know why it took me so long to get a Test 100 at my home ground. I had obviously always felt some pressure playing in front of my home crowd, and the expectation for me to do well is higher there than anywhere else. Still, nothing gives me more pleasure than scoring runs in front of the Newlands crowd. It's not easy, though – especially in Test cricket – as on the first day the Newlands wicket is always quite lively. In